

Speaker 2: 00:00

Awesome. Okay, yeah.

Speaker 1: 00:04

I'm not leaving meeting. It gave me an option I could leave. It's like, oh, okay, bye. Nice meeting you. I'm going away now.

Speaker 2: 00:14

Record you and then you leave. Yeah,

Speaker 1: 00:16

exactly. How dare you record me an important person like myself-

Speaker 1: 00:28

don't worry, you'll get used to me after a while. It's okay.

Speaker 1: 00:31

It's okay. I enjoy this. I enjoy this. I like I like these kind of these kind of interactions are definitely very fun. Um, so are you ready to get started?

Speaker 2: 00:43

Sure, absolutely. I have no idea what we could possibly talk about for a whole hour. But you know, I assume you've done a few of these. So go right ahead.

Speaker 2: 00:52

Yeah, so that will take like, lots of hours and I'm taking like, 45 minutes. 40 minutes. I'm gonna take like an hour.

Speaker 1: 00:58

We'll talk fast. Oh, good, Lord. Okay. Yeah, let's get started.

Speaker 2: 01:06

Yeah, okay, fine. So thank you, again, for participating in this interview. As mentioned over text and email, we want to know more about your views on romantic relationships. And we believe your experience and perspective would be much this project. Um, I already asked him before we start recording, I need to ask you again for the recording is all right, if we record this interview, yes,

Speaker 1: 01:27

you may record this interview. Awesome.

Speaker 2: 01:29

Okay. I'm just so just in demographical questions. How old are you? Oh,

Speaker 1: 01:35

God, I'm going to do math. [66-70] going to be [66-70]. Like next week?

Speaker 2: 01:45

Oh my goodness, happy early birthday. How long have you been together with your partner?

Speaker 1: 01:52

We've been together since [Year]. Before you were born before you were born. That's just an obscene amount of time, by the way. Okay.

Speaker 2: 02:05

Yes. Yeah. Do you have any children?

Speaker 1: We do not.

Speaker 2: Okay. And who lives in the household?

Speaker 1: 02:16

He lives in the household right there. Hi. Do we count cats and dogs?

Speaker 2: 02:22

I guess if you want to Yeah,

Speaker 1: 02:24

sure. We have a dog. And we have [1-5] cats. That's the whole that's the whole household. That's that's the entire thing.

Speaker 2: 02:31

love that. I love that. Animals are great. Yeah, they're awesome. Exactly. Um, and what is your main source of income? And like, what is your current job?

Speaker 1: 02:40

So I just retired, like, yeah, right. Well, actually, technically speaking. I'm on annual leave. I'm not retired till Friday. But I've been gone on annually for a month. So technically, I just retired. I was a [occupation] at the [location] for [36-40] years, again, obscene amount of time. So now I am a broke retiree. So I will have a [occupation] pension, which is just really impressive. And social security, and [plan] plan. So yeah, that'll be that'll be our money. [redacted]. I don't know. We'll figure it out. Cause dude. I am way too old to work the streets. So I have you know, I only have so much to work with here. So but yeah, our legitimate income. It's gonna be pensions. Yeah.

Speaker 2: Okay, okay. Well if you ever need anyone to see drugs to.

Speaker 1: Yes. Excellent. God. Excellent. Put her on the list. [Name]. Okay. Thank you. I'll just start a shortlist now.

Speaker 2: 03:51

Don;t worry, I have a lot of money, so I will be getting a lot of drugs for you.

Speaker 1: 03:55

Oh, excellent. Just awesome. I'm sure your parents will be really pleased about that.

Speaker 2: 04:04

100% Anyways, would you like us to address your partner?

Speaker 1: 04:15

I used to call him hey, you idiot. So I think [Partner's Name] is good. He usually goes by his last name [Partner's Name]. Yeah, you can call him by its nickname which is [Nickname]. But you'd probably be more comfortable calling him [Partner's Name].

Speaker 2: 04:29

[Partner's Name]. Okay. Sounds good. Sounds good. Okay, and then shifting gears a little bit. Um, can you tell us about like, tell me sorry. Tell me about like your love story. ,

Speaker 1: 04:40

sure. So we were this is so such old history. We were working at [Company] on [Location], streets gone down on [Location]. I was a [occupation], he was the [occupation]. He was married. Sorry. And he was pretty much fresh off the boat, as you will discover in a little bit. He's wasn't born here. So fresh off the boat security guard, just the guy in the corner. I was [20-25]. He was [26-30]. And he just a guy, you know, just the guy with a uniform, the dumb guy in the corner. But because [Company] had all really young [occupation]. We were the only store that had young [occupation]. Then, of course, we talked to him and he was just just over there. didn't pay any attention to until one day I kind of started paying attention to him. And at the time, he had really [description] hair, and it's really cute. It's like, he's kind of cute. But I wasn't interested at all. I was not in a relationship at the time that I'd been in relationships. I didn't want to get tied down. I was really independent had my own apartment. And like my life, everything was fine. I was going to school, you know, it's like whatever. And I think he Yeah, he quit. I got to think about this long time ago, you know, he got a job at the [company], which was a really good step up for somebody who just arrived. And he was leaving. This is after we'd worked together for a couple of years. So he was going to go and he took me out to dinner to steak me for being really really nice to him while I was working there. And of course I was all the girls were nice to him. And so and he didn't want to go because he was like, this is weird. No, and it was so long ago that we're halfway through the date, which was at this really little hole in the wall [restaurant] restaurant division. Halfway through the day, I got up and called my mother on the payphone. Do we even know what a payphone is? Okay, good. Okay, good. called my mother on my mother. That's how young I was. Call my mother in a payphone. It's like, this is weird. You know, I'm here like, we call them [Partner's Name] at the time. We're here with [Partner's Name] and like, I don't know. I mean, I think you might like me, but no idea. I ever it was just odd. Anyway, he drove me home and never left. Yeah, that was it. That was it. I didn't want a guy. I didn't want a guy in my life. I didn't want this guy. I didn't. There wasn't. I went from being absolutely not attracted to him to being you know, totally head over heels madly in love. He divorced his wife. We got together. That's it. That's our love story. And I never invited him to move in. Which is what I want to know what this man is doing here. I guess you he just like, it just went from nothing to something. without us even knowing it. It was really strange. Yeah.

Speaker 2: 08:11

Well, thanks for sharing that. That's a really interesting love story. I really like it. It's yeah,

Speaker 1: 08:19

it's really it's really strange. It's really really, really weird. Because it was like he was and he was totally like, not my type. I didn't even really know what country he was from, at all. Like, seriously, I would didn't I didn't know. Like, I had a vague concept. He's like, Oh, he's what? Where is that? Who were those people that it was [Year]. So it wasn't like now we're like, there's this particular group of people is everywhere. Any [Store Name] store. And so like, I didn't, I didn't even I seriously did not know what the guy was. Just yeah, I guess I didn't know. It's weird. And that's not the way I met anybody else. Like my other previous relationships. That was definitely not the way a

fact it was definitely more of a like ooh, that's really sad that I was with somebody I really went after some totally pursued. No, this one is not at all. It works up I guess we're still here.

Speaker 2: 09:25

that's so funny.

Speaker 1: 09:26

Yeah. It's weird. I know. It's weird.

Speaker 2: 09:32

How would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to that of your friends relationships?

Speaker 1: 09:39

Oh, gosh. So let's think depends on which friends we're talking about. I think that we have maybe I do have some happily married or paired off friends have to think about this. So I have two groups of friends, I've got friends that are in long term relationships that I know, haven't worked for a really long time. But they stay together, and they just can't ever seem to. I know that I know that, like, I'm friends with the women, so that I know that women are unhappy, but they don't leave the guys. And they have bad relationships, but they don't leave. And then I have friends who are in really good relationships that are so I want to say on a par with our relationship, even though they haven't been together as long. But I'm gonna actually divide it up in my brain. So my friends who are close to my age, because most of my friends are younger. So my friends that are close to my age of that group, one who is closest to my age, is been in a long term marriage with a guy that she should never have married, and their relationship is crap. It's bad, she should have left him wanting years ago, and she didn't. And that's never gonna happen now. So our relationship obviously is better than that. The next one, again, Age, Group wise, is in a good but volatile relationship with her husband, they've been married about [20-25] years getting to [16-20] years younger than I am. So quite a big age gap. But their relationship is closer to ours, I would say. But there's a lot more volatility, a lot more hurt feelings going on. So there's that. And then I have friends who have come from other relationships, again, friends that are way younger than I am. And they've got a pretty solid relationships. But they haven't been together very long, like less than [6-10] years or less. Let's call it that. I think I'm thinking, Yeah, I want to say that we're probably the happiest couple that I know. I think so. I really do. Yeah, I think we're running them over. I'm really each one of them over in my head and how many times are getting fights, how many times they have issues. What I think is the level of satisfaction they're getting from their relationship? Yeah, I think we're probably the happiest people all the way around. But I also think some of that, too, is age. Because some of that is you do sort of the rough edges. And you're prickliness Especially like females, because I hate to throw us under the bus. But can I say I'll stereotype females. But I think that if there's somebody that's going to be bitchy, it's going to be the woman. Which is why it's a problem if you get two women together, because then you've got two women who potentially are going to have a bitch fest going on. But if I think that women tend to be more volatile, and the women I know tend to be more volatile, we tend to be the ones that are more demanding in the relationship. The guys always want to kind of like let everything go. Don't understand why we can't let things go. I think you as you get older, you start learning to let things go, you start prioritizing what what's worth picking battles, what's worth fighting about what's not worth fighting about. So when you're annoyed because he's chewing too loud, it's probably better just to turn up your headset or something than it is to start screaming about him is about to add to him about something else, because you're really annoyed because he's chewing too loud. So you start yelling because he didn't clean the cat box. So yeah, right, that kind of thing. But I think when

you're younger, you're thinking you tend to do more of that. Like you're so focused on wanting everything to be good that when things aren't good. You really you're trying to fix them. You're trying to control the way that they behave, which isn't to say that he isn't still dragging a wall a lot of the time he does, but not as much because I let things go more whereas some of my younger friends. They haven't hit that let it Go mode. They will. And I tell them they will. So yeah, eventually, eventually, you're just gonna let a lot of this stuff just wash over the top of you and realize that this is not worth getting into some big fight and stomping out of the house because of something really minor. But yeah, I think we're still think we're probably one of the happier couples I know. Content. Yeah. And I think we're still not maybe not madly in love, but definitely in love or still have a really deep love for one another. So yeah, that helps. That helps a lot. But if you've fallen completely out of love with somebody, then what's the point? At that point? You have a roommate.

Speaker 2: 15:43

Yeah. Yeah, exactly. No, I think I think I mean, that sounds really great. And that actually brings me to like another question, which is, for you, what is love?

15:57

Well, I think I think there's an actual physiological response to another person. For me, there's always been I mean, when I fall in love with somebody, it's usually I'm usually blindsided by it. So I think that there's, it just happens. One minute, you're just a person. And the next minute, you're like, oh, shit, I think I'm falling in love with this person. Oh, no, right. Which by the way can happen whether or not you act on it or not. So even though I'm in a very long term, committed relationship, it isn't to say that I haven't fallen in love with people during this time, that you can feel this feel this, oh, my God, this, I can't stop this feeling that is a physical presence. And you recognize it from having done it before. So it's the it's a physiological response. And obviously, there's also a, there's a physical attraction. So that kind of goes hand in hand. So I think you almost can't have one without the other. But I think that once you get the physiological one kicking in all of a sudden, the ugliest guy in the room, you're like, Oh, God, I think I kind of like his geekiness. So I kind of like, what you wouldn't normally be attracted to. Whatever it is that you you know, if you love gorgeous guys, or you'd like geeky guys, whatever it happens to be. If he's not your type, you kind of can override that. Because your body is telling you or your I guess, brought against your brain, your brain is telling you that this person fits into this category that you are feeling a response to them. That isn't just physical, that and then of course, we get into a whole nother thing, whether it's a sexual response. Because if you if that then the problem there is that that kind of usually with most of us, overrides everything else, including your good judgment. So when the guy is just so incredibly hot, you can't stand it, you've got to have him or else, then you don't have to be in love with them. And you don't have to care what type he is just like your body just going yeah, that now immediately, boom. So I think that love. True love is a combination of feeling. A feeling within your body that you can't control of being attracted not sexually, but attracted to this other person. And then it's helps to cancel out some whatever your objections might be, if this guy doesn't fit into the categories that you would normally be choosing. So I really think that it's something that you can't control, you're going to fall in love with somebody, you're going to fall in love with them, whether you want to or not, whether you were anticipating or not, whether it was on your list of things to do, whether you're looking for relationship or not, which is why I tell all of the young women I run into, go out and do everything that you want to do. Because right in the middle of making all of your plans of all the things you're going to do, you will find somebody, you will fall in love with somebody somewhere and everything that you had on your list that you were going to do goes out the window, because now you have to incorporate his or her plans into yours. And it's like, oh my god, so quick before you fall in love with somebody go do stuff. That's my advice.

Speaker 2: 19:31

I actually like that advice, because that's what I'm doing right now. And I think it's working well. So I'm glad. I'm glad that I'm hearing that from someone else as well.

Speaker 1: 19:39

Yeah, because you don't know, right? We could end this interview. You could turn around, go get yourself a coffee, and he or she could be there. And it's like, oh my God, no, go away. I'm not ready. You're not in my [1-5] year plan. And of course, the problem is that when you really do fall I met with somebody if they are available and willing. And if it's reciprocal, then yeah, there goes your five year plan. It's out the window. Now you've got to make a five year plan together.

Speaker 2: 20:11

Yep. Yeah. Yeah. And for you how important is love in a relationship?

Speaker 1: 20:17

Oh, it's, yeah, for me, it is impossible. If you didn't have it. I can't, I know there are people that make relationships work. And I got like one friend who's just been serial dating for ever. And I think she's at the point where she's willing to just settle down with a nice good companion, because love just hasn't worked out to this point. If if she falls in love, and he turns out to be a jerk, or he's lying to her all the time, whatever it is. And I can understand why she's willing to settle for it, because she's just given up at this point. But yeah, for me, no, I cannot imagine. I guess I was lucky. Because the relationships I've been in, were with people I was in love with first and therefore found that. And so I can't imagine anything. Otherwise. I can't imagine that [Partner's Name] and I would have gotten together if we hadn't. If I hadn't been in love with him. And he'd been in love with me, we wouldn't be together. It just wouldn't have happened. And I've had other you know, obviously, all of us have people that tell tell us that they're in love with us. And believe it or not, I used to be young. So, you know, he used to happen with relative frequency. where there'd be some guy going Oh, my God, I'm in love with you. And you're like, Yeah, bye. mean, that was nice, but it just wasn't gonna happen. So, no matter. Yeah, I never got into a relationship with somebody who I wasn't in love with. I never. I slept with people I wasn't in love with but that's different. That's not a relationship. Yeah.

Speaker 2: 22:05

Yeah. How do you know that your partner loves you? Or [Partner's Name]?

22:10

Um, I think I can, I think I can tell when somebody I think I've always been able to tell when someone's been in love with me. So I think all people have that instinct, maybe they don't. I think I don't know. It's always been perfectly obvious. Like, you know, from my high school on, you could always tell when somebody in the class was in love with you, even if you weren't in love with them. So I think you can tell without them telling you. You can definitely tell by the time the poor guy spits it out. Easily. That moment, and you know, the moment where you are that you if he's scared to say it, because he's afraid you won't say it back. And usually, by the time you get to that point, you've both known for a little while that you're in love. And he's in love, and you're just waiting to get to that point of saying it. So I know it because he said it. And then of course over the course of time, I know it because of the way that he behaves. Because he wouldn't behave this way if he didn't love me. And especially at this point in our in our lives, because, you know, I'm no longer the cute [20-25] year old. So if he didn't love me, he'd be gone. He's got no other options. And yeah, he just would be and somebody I for that matter. But yeah, I know he is. I think he does. I know he,

he loves me, because he says it all the time. I know it because of the way he behaves. And I know it because there's nothing to tell me otherwise. So yeah, just behavior. And then and yeah, the whole thing about you know, madly in love and he walks into the room. I can't breathe. Yeah, that's over for a while now. But but in love, being in love and loving somebody is two separate items as well. I think that we stayed in love for a really, really long time, like, probably [26-30] years. Really, really, really, really long time. I don't know that we're necessarily in love with one another at this point. Probably not. But then you get the deeper love and the Yeah, yeah, that's it. I can't I can't find a different way to explain that. So I hope that works.

Speaker 2: 24:35

Yeah, that makes a lot of sense for sure. And can ask him a romantic partner as you've had in the past.

Speaker 1: 24:46

romantic partners as in people I've slept with, or people that I've had long term relationships with.

Speaker 2: 24:53

In this case, long term relationships with

Speaker 1: 24:56

Oh, I see not too many likes. [1-5] Yeah, yeah. Prior to? Yeah.

Speaker 2: 25:06

How would you compare the quality of like your current relationship to like your previous relationships?

Speaker 1: 25:13

Oh, gosh, okay, so the first [1-5], we can just discount because they were, you know, the, the newborn, the, you know, [16-20] or whatever it was at the time. And the guy that moves in and you know, it's all lovely, but it's really, it's long term, but short term, relatively speaking. You really weren't meant to be together to begin with, it's mainly a sexual attraction. And the fact that you want a boyfriend, he wants a girlfriend, you, you have the freedom of having left school. And you're, you know, you get to be adult, you get to adult for a minute, or pretend that you're an adult. So I want to say both of those. Yeah, don't even discount them completely. Just, I don't even remember that. The third one was a disaster, the guy that I should never have been with, at all. There he was, he was in love with me. I don't think I was ever in love with him. But he was a means to an end, I wanted to I had moved back in with my parents, I was out of school. And I wanted to get away from [Location A], he was in [Location B]. And I had a great excuse for getting away, gave me somebody who could help me establish myself in [Location B]. He had a he was a lot older than I was, let me think he was [26-30]. I was [20-25]. And so he had this really sort of wild group of friends hanging out on the [Location], those types of friends. And therefore I could have those friends, I could have all of them. So I very much sort of took advantage of his relationships with other people. And in order to be able to move out of my parents house. I think that was the final time because it kept moving back and forth. And he Yeah, it was interesting, but a complete disaster. And I we didn't belong together should never have been together. I think he was gay anyway. I think ultimately. And that, you know, so but yeah, he wasn't it wasn't going to work out long term. But he was very that's what I want to use for him. He was very movie star ish. There's one I want to use. He was [Nationality]. And he was [description]. And he was very interesting looking at he had this fabulous wardrobe. And he had all these glamorous friends. And he was sort of the entree into that world in [Location B]. Because at the time, that's what I wanted to do. And

you know, we hung out a lot on nude beaches with all the beautiful people. There's a really long time ago. And but it was, as far as a relationship went, it was a disaster it was in, there was never, there was not any real love there. There was just a couple of people that for a moment got into each other's orbit. And believe me when he went out the door, I was never so happy to see the back of somebody. Because I was like, Yeah, please, please leave. Just go. You've been? You've been a huge mistake. There. Yeah. So this is the I guess this is my only decent relationship. Is this one here? I guess that makes a difference to Yeah. And there's which is why I've stuck with it. Because if it hadn't been good, I am somebody that would leave. So if it hadn't worked out, I would be would have been out of here a long time ago.

Speaker 2: 29:15

Yeah, that makes sense, actually. Yeah. And for you what makes a relationship higher high quality or low quality?

Speaker 1: 29:28

I, I think that you have to spend a lot of time together. So you have to really want to be together. You want to be in the same room, you want to do the same. You shouldn't say you want to do the same things, but the things that you do together, whatever it happens to be that if you both like named something [interest]. If you both enjoy [interest], you have to both want to be mountain climbing together. Right? It's fine. If you'd like to [interest] you don't like to [interest]. Send him off with his friends to go [interest] and you go off with your friends. Do whatever it is that he doesn't like to do, and then get back together and do something you do like to do together, I think you have to have things that you enjoy doing together, I think you have to have things that plans that you've made for the future, like, don't think that you can just deal with whatever's going on today, I think that you have to have something to look forward to both of you equally in the relationship, you have to see a future together and be excited about what it is you're going to do next. If you don't have that, you're kind of doomed. Because your, your relationships gonna die. You as much as I love sitting in the sun, reading a book and drinking coffee, you can't just do that, if that's all your relationship is based on is doing the same thing over and over again. And there's nothing that's pulling you forward, your relationship isn't gonna grow, you're not gonna, you're what worked for you, you're gonna be bored. What worked for you this year isn't gonna work for you next year. So I think you have to be constantly evolving, changing, that you have to do it together. And I think that's what happens with a lot of relationships is one person moves on and the other person stays where they were. So I'm not the [20-25] year old that he moved in with. And he's not the [26-30] year old that I would love to move in with me. Yeah, apparently. We're not the same person. We've, but we've got to move forward together at the same pace, and made plans together and agreed on what those plans are going to be. And Which isn't to say that we're up in each other's shit all the time, because we're not. I have gone on vacations without him with friends. He has gone on vacations with friends without me. We aren't always doing the same thing all of the time. We are not in lockstep. He has different interests. I have different interests. We do something separately. We all do a lot of things together. And I think super simple stuff. Like we like to go out to breakfast. We're still excited about going out to breakfast. If I want to make him happy. I will offer him breakfast tomorrow morning, when I go out to breakfast. Okay, it just popped his head up like a gopher. Swear to God did it dumb stuff like that. I know that that makes him happy. It makes me happy. We have good breakfasts, we talk during breakfast. We're not one of the couples that sits in the restaurant and doesn't speak to one another. Even though we've been together since [Year]. We still have things to say to one another. We still have active plans that we're making. We have plans, we have things going on next week, we have things going on the week after that we have things that we're doing. I think that you've got to work on staying engaged with one another and with your lives together. And that if you don't have that it's almost a death knell. Because you've

got to care about what you're going to do with this person, next week or next month or next year. And if you don't, the relationship has probably run its course. I've got a friend again, somebody who's close to my age, she has a really interesting theory, which is she thinks that people shouldn't be like swans, we shouldn't mate for life. She thinks she should have different people for the different phases of your life. And what she's basing this on? Yeah, right. Think about that. She's basing this on the fact that she had a really good long term relationship with her husband, they had four children together. They immigrated here from [Country], they didn't speak [Language]. When they came. They had to build up businesses that they did from scratch. They learn to speak [Language], they had the [1-5] beautiful children. They had a great relationship. They had a great house, they had an exciting life. And the minute of the kids were out of the house, the relationship was just over. And the way she saw it is that they were should have been together just for having that family. And that once that family was raised, and they've done that, that they should split up. That's it. They no longer served a purpose in one another's lives. And they didn't they truly didn't. And they did actually eventually divorce. But I thought it was a really interesting idea because of course I mean, we haven't done that obviously. But to me what's telling is that for me, [Partner's Name] worked when I was [20-25], he worked when I was [30-35]. He worked when I was [40-45]. To [50-55], he worked when I was [60-65]. And he's still continuing to work. So as long as the relationship is continuing to work, and you're still feel that you're moving together through life at a pace that you want to, and that you're both looking forward to things together, or, if not necessarily, together, he's looking forward to the fact that I'm going to a [Team Name] game with my friends, and it's like, Oh, good, she's gonna go have a good time. And I'm looking forward to the fact that he's gonna go out to lunch with his friends, and they're gonna have a good time. So doesn't have to be in the same room. But you have to be happy that the person is going off and doing something, if you no longer care, that it's like, oh, you're going to lunch with your friends? So what why are we why even bother telling me? Your relationships had it?

Speaker 2: 35:54

Yeah, that makes a lot of sense. And especially on like, growth, and like, communication, all those sorts of things. Would you say? Like, any relationship is one that like, has good communication? And like, where you go together?

Speaker 1: 36:11

Yeah, I think you have to have first you have to have good communication, you have to have communication, just to begin with, you have to be willing to listen to each other talk about something or express what they need to do. That's probably something that we probably if we have trouble with anything, it's I like to be really precise in what I'm saying. And I want to make sure that he really understands it. And he wants me to shortcut that. And he's like, Yeah, I got you. And I'm like, No, I want to know that you understand what I'm saying? So he said, Yeah, you know, I just want to like cut to the chase, just tell me what the subject is. Tell me what the subject is, why do you have to go all the way around the bushes in order to get there. But because I'm trying to, to justify my position on something, I'll be explaining it, as you can probably tell, I can talk a lot. And so I will be explaining it to the nth degree. And he's like, Okay, I got that, like, five minutes ago, why are we still talking about it, then it's like, Oh, fine. But you have to be able to communicate, if, if he isn't talking, if he's sitting in the living room. And at a time when he would normally be throwing out little comments, or being verbal, and he's very, very, very quiet, something's wrong. He doesn't feel well, something's hurting, he's got a headache. He's feeling dizzy. He's upset about something, which really doesn't happen, because he's not like that. But there's something off. So literally communication. There's like, what's the matter? It's nothing. Something's the matter. Tell me what's matter, you, I think you have to be constantly checking in with one another, to see where you're where that other person is. Because you might be having a great day when they're

having a crap day. And if they're having a crap day, then you either have to pull them out of the crap day, or you have to allow them to wallow in it for a while. But you have to understand that if they're having a crap day, and they want to wallow in it, that you can't push them out of it, you can say, Would it help if you went and got ice cream? But if that wouldn't help, it's like, okay, fine, let's just watch TV or something, and just let them wallow for a while. But if you didn't bother asking what was the matter? And if they weren't able to tell you what was the matter, because they didn't trust you, Or because they didn't think you'd be you'd validate your feelings. Again, I think you're probably lost. So you have to be able to communicate with your partner about dumb stuff and about important stuff. But if you're, if you're not talking to one another, a lot. I think it can be detrimental. It and you need to get your your feelings out about things. You can't, you can't. Sometimes I will think that I've got a problem that he can't solve as well, so I won't bother telling him. Usually if I tell him, he can solve it, I've thought that he can't. But he'll say something that'll either solve it, or make me see a way that I can solve it, or make me at least feel better about the way I feel. So it's also sharing that burden of whatever it is it's bothering when you've got something. And if and if you have some crisis that you're both dealing with. Again, you have to talk about it. You've got to be able to say those literally say those words to one another in order to make that problem, go away, or to lessen that problem, or to at least get to the agreement with one another that you can't fix it but it's okay well doing this together. So even though we're gonna have to suffer through this, we're both, you know, it's we're both we can do it. We can we'll, we'll get through this together. So yeah, communication. Got it. Gotta have it.

Speaker 2: 40:14

Yeah. And when would you say had good communication, like what happened then, like, Give an example or something.

Speaker 1: 40:22

Okay, examples. I'm trying to think of one where we had where I'm trying to get back to something, like a crisis kind of thing. Because that's usually where? Well, actually, let's not do a crisis. Let's talk about this is to be more fun. All right. So because I've just retired, then, I'm all up in my head about, oh, my God, you know, the money, the money is a concern. I live in [Location A], we do own our own house, but high property taxes. And you know, I'd like to spend money, everyone likes us. Not on frivolous things. I like to spend money on useful things. But nonetheless, it's money. And I try to be careful not to be too don't buy things to be pretentious. But if I, if I want something, I want it. And oh, my God, I'm not going to be able to buy this anymore, or I can't get my nails done, or I can't, I shouldn't be spending money on I'm gonna have to suddenly, you know, pull back and not have any money, oh, my God, I'm going to be very poor. So I've been we've been in my head about trying to figure out what we're going to do about it. We talked a long time ago, we have an inlaw. Downstairs. So we talked a long time ago about maybe moving down to the in law renting the upper part of the house. But there's a lot of speed bumps in the way about doing that. And so I just play these tapes over and over Okay, Option A, option B, Option C, because we had the upper part, we could rent the lower part. But here's the problem with that we could rent the upper part. And here's the problems with that. We could rent both parts to one family, we could read both parts to different families, we could move somewhere else, we can move to a trailer, we could move to an RV. We could go live in a tent we could Go and get an apartment in some fictitious city that we would love that had great burritos that would be very inexpensive, and have a patio. Oh my god, oh my god. Oh my god. So this is all doing this in my brain. So we went to breakfast. We went to breakfast. And I said, Okay, so you know, Option A or Option B. We've discussed this before many times, but not in depth. And recently. Option A, option B, Option C option D oh my god, oh my god, oh my God. And he just looks at me. And he's like, Yeah, we're moving downstairs. Really? And in that moment, I said, because if we stay upstairs, we have light and air. But if we move downstairs

we have freedom. It was like, Oh, yeah. Okay. Done. Now I got it. Because he was able to literally communicate that to me with words, to say it out loud, to get me out of spinning in my head over all of these options, which have pros and cons. And they all do everything in life has pros and cons. But he was able to just kind of very succinctly very, I was really surprised, because he hadn't. It's been floating around. But he hadn't really said yeah, I'm committed to this, like, Oh, my God, okay, fine. Fine. Now we move forward. And we are that is we've got the wheels are now in motion to have a friend of ours who contractor come and do some work downstairs so that we can make that happen. And we've kind of hashed out some of the plans. But it's literally the communication of me saying this is currently what's bothering me, what the heck are we going to do, and him feeding back? A really succinct response. That makes total sense. So if we didn't communicate, I would still have everything spinning in my head. And he would be you know, off walking the dog not knowing that was a problem. So I wasn't going to tell them. Like, I'm not going to say, oh my god, I'm so depressed because I don't know what we're going to do. I was too stuck with my brain to be able to even spit it out at that point. And he didn't know that I was having that issue. He thought that well yeah, we have all these great choices. You know, we'll pick just one of the great choices that we have and I'm not thinking of them as great choices. I realize on some level that they are. But at that point, I was stuck. So yeah, that was literal communication. Really just saying the words out loud, to make it make perfect sense that there was really only one really logical choice and one sensible choice. And now it's like, oh, okay, we're good. And we'll work on that project next. And we're excited, which is stupid. We're just really stupid, which is really stupid. We're excited, we get to move to the basement. But it's another chapter. It's, you know, again, we're working on a project together. Okay, now we're going to redo the bathroom down there. So that we're going to, and what are we going to do with all of this, the furniture upstairs and downstairs. So let's clean through things and get that done, let's shape our new lives together, let's figure out what this is going to look like. So that we do have financial freedom, which equals physical freedom. And yeah, why would we not? Why wouldn't we choose this seems very obvious once he pointed it out. But it wasn't obvious in the, you know, [1-5] weeks preceding that.

Speaker 2: 46:09

It's amazing. And you can tell us like, a little bit in your previous answers, but I'm wondering, for you, what is the most important thing in relationship or like the most important things, it can be multiple things?

Speaker 1: 46:29

I think for the most important things in relationship is that I think that you have to look out for one another. I think that if you don't do that, I think that and I think that a lot of people don't do that in their relationships that they don't want. It's it's little things. Like, is it think of it in terms of the way that you would look out for a child or look out for our pet? Except that in this case, it's another adult. And so to make sure that they're comfortable to you know, Is he is he hungry? Is he hangry? Is he doesn't need a blanket. Is he sitting on the couch? And even though he's you know, he looks okay, but are you cold? You know, do I need to get you a blanket. Little tiny fear giving things, I think are what maybe what's a little bit different about our relationship than what I see in friends relationships, where they don't do that. And again, I'll give you an example, which is something that didn't occur to me to somebody pointed out to me, we'd gone to [Location] with friends. And everybody was doubling up on rooms because they had gotten them all free. And so we had will be he and I were in a room with a double bed. We had one bed and then I had a girlfriend who had the other bed. And she went in to brush her teeth. Believe it or not, this story is going somewhere. When you brush your teeth and came out and said and she's in a really she's married, right. And so she came out and she said, Oh my god, [Partner's Name] puts the toothpaste on your toothbrush for you. I'm like, yeah, it's because he's putting toothpaste on his

toothbrush, and he went to brush his teeth first. So he puts it on his and he puts it on mine. Like I don't understand, and she says I would love it if [Name] would do something like that. And I thought, Oh my god. Okay. Like it never occurred to me. That that would that because [Partner's Name]'s always done that. For as long as I've known him. He's done little tiny things like that. Little tiny, considerate things. But I didn't know it's nice. But it didn't occur to me that other people don't have that, or that other guys wouldn't do that. And it was funny because I didn't say it to her. But I told [Partner's Name] later that night that [Name] had commented on it. And I knew what his response would be, which is when she went in the morning to brush her teeth. He'd put toothpaste on her toothbrush too. So here's toothpaste on all three of our toothbrushes. But it's like little tiny, taking care of each other things that I think I see other husbands or other wives don't do because it never occurred to them to do it. It doesn't occur to them, if I go downstairs to work on the computer, and I've been down there for more than let's call it like [40-45] minutes, a cup of coffee or cup of tea will arrive unasked for, because, okay, you're going to be down for a while, you know, whatever. And I think that little tiny gestures like that make a huge difference. Not even that they make a huge difference to us, but the lack of those make a difference in other people's relationships, that they don't have that. And that they don't. I mean, I look out for him as well, I do the same thing. He just does it more than I do it. But I think I'm more needy than his. But he definitely, you know, from the beginning of our relationship, when we first got together, I used to work a shift until [time] in the morning. And I never thought anything of it. I just, you know, go home on the [transportation] and not think anything of it. But as soon as he moved in, he started picking me up at three in the morning. And even though he had to be up at five to go to work. And I thought, yeah, I mean, I'm fine. I'm a big girl, I live in [Location A], I'm perfectly capable of taking it. There was no [transportation] tip. But I could take a cab if I didn't feel like taking the [transportation], I'd take the [transportation]. And you know, I can get home on my own, you'll come down and get me he's like, No. So from the beginning, he did things like that, because that is his instinct, his instinct is to take care of the other person. And I think that that's actually a really important factor is you need to take care of one another watch out for one another, have each other's backs. And that's probably that and we're gonna throw this in. You can't disagree about money. Because that's the thing that kills. That's probably that and infidelity are probably the two things that kill most relationships. You argue about money you don't. And we are very different about money. I am a squirrel. I squirrel money away in every if you want to come rob my house, look in the corners. There's money everywhere. I've got money squirreled away I am a saver. I always have money tucked away, because oh my god, you just never know what's going to happen. He is total spender, he has no idea. He's only recently learned to even look at the checkbook balance. And that's only because I see you have to because I'm going to retire and you must look to see how much money we have. So you're not standing at [Restaurant Name] with him rejecting your debit card. So you need to actually hear, look, this is the app, you must look how much is in the account. We get paid every [1-5] weeks, you need to look at that. But he's only done that recently. He doesn't look at prices, he doesn't pay attention to prices, he likes to shop, he loves clothes, you like to spend money, he likes to go out and do things. He loves to go out and eat. He I am. I love all those things, too. But I've definitely got an eye on the money. But we don't fight about money. We have never once ever, in all this time ever fought about money. And I think that's probably really uncommon. I think that most people fight a lot about money. We don't. And that's including, you know, he, I need to send money home, we send money home, if I need to, you know, I want to buy I bought my mom a car when she was alive. And I said I'm gonna buy my own car. She's like, Yeah, buy our car. You know, he knows that I, I already checked to make sure we can make the payments. But we don't fight about it. We don't disagree on it. Invariably, if we have a budget for something, we're gonna go buy a new stove. We agree on a budget, we will both probably exceed the budget. Because we want a higher end stove. And we both agree that we looked at the cheaper ones, we don't like them, we'll buy the more expensive one. And we're both

going to be happy about it. But I think that those two for me for my relationship. Those two factors have made a huge difference in the fact that we take care of one another consistently through all of these years, and that we don't fight about money ever. So yeah, that's it. I don't I don't have anything else. Any other big secret. I don't think it's about planning romantic dinners on the beach so that you can kindle the flame. I just it doesn't, you know, he would just laugh at me for that anyway. But I don't think it's that. I think it's just yeah, I know people do and that's fine. If that's what you need if you need him to send you flowers. If he needs you to send him flowers, whatever it happens to be. If you need to make it You know, oh my God, I need him to make a big deal on my birthday. If that's what floats your boat and fine, it doesn't happen to be my choice. For me, it's just comes down to two things that if we didn't do those things, that I think it would make a huge difference. If we didn't take care of one another and we fought about money. I don't think that we would have been together this long.

Speaker 2: 55:29

And do you and your partner fight about other things

Speaker 1: 55:37

if we're going to fight about and we don't fight very often see what's actually really hate fighting he really hates fight. So I want to say that if we fight about anything, it's usually over a miscommunication of some kind. Generally speaking over something where I've want him to acknowledge my point of view on something. And he won't admit that he's acknowledging the point of view, in his many words. And it'll go from being absolutely fine to yelling at each other, to both stomping off to our corners of the house for [20-25] hours, to then apologizing to not fighting anymore. That's it, because we both really actually hate fighting. He thinks it's just pointless. His his comment is always if we're going to fight and just let's not be together, just That's it, we're done. If you don't love me anymore, move out. If I don't love you anymore, move out. But don't bother fighting. It's just not worth it. So we're not we're definitely not one of those couples that fights all the time that are always in a fight, that are all was making up after a fight. We probably in all this time. How many years is this? I can't do the math [Year] [Year]. So really long time Good lord. We've probably had, I want to say less than [20-25] fights in that time. And I want to say more like [11-15]. But yeah, but maybe I'm sure he hurt my feelings at some point when I was younger. So let's call it [20-25]. But I think that that averages out to what one fight every [1-5] years. Oh, that's not bad. I mean, most most people I know, usually, if you know they're in a fight every few months, if not more often. I've known some couples that have gone and some couples that have gotten really, like the fights are almost to the level of calling the cops kind of fights with couples that are no longer together, but really, really, really, really ugly fights. I don't think that we've ever had that kind of an ugly fight. I do remember stomping out one time and going to live in my car for a couple of hours. But that was a long time ago. But yeah. I don't think we've ever gotten into anything like that. And but most couples I know probably fight about

58:34

maybe if we fight once every [1-5] years, they fight at least [10-15] times every [1-5] years. And usually over usually over something with a relatives I want to say some family issues, that kind of thing. They get the the last fights my friends have gotten into Yeah, usually over that.

Speaker 2: 59:06

You say like your fights last or lasted?

Speaker 1: 59:09

Oh, our fights last, less like overnight. So if we're getting into a fight at two in the afternoon, we just don't speak to each other for the rest of the day. And then we're fine in the morning. So it's good to fight later in the day. Because, you know, if you get in a fight at six o'clock, and you're you know, it's over by 6am It's over the next day, we both just sleep on it and then we realize how stupid it is. And we really neither one of us want to fight with one another. And so he will come and say he's sorry, even if he doesn't think he was wrong. Or you know, he's always wrong. But he will always come and apologize just to get it over with like, okay, that it's just sort of a truce like Okay, fine. That was unpleasant. It screwed up our evening. Instead of having a nice evening together at home, you went to your room and read and I went downstairs and watch TV. And we could have had a really nice evening instead, and we didn't. And wasn't that stupid. So yeah, they only they last until if, until overnight. Or if they happen early in the day, we don't want it to go into overnight, then they like, yeah, so, you know, eight hours is probably our maximum. We just don't go that long. It's pointless, because honestly, he's right. If you're going to be fighting all the time, don't be together. Because if you're whatever it is, you're fighting about. If you can't fix whatever that is, who wants to be like that? Imagine if that was your workplace. Or imagine if that was your, you know, your go to school. Imagine if you went you went in every time you went into a class, you got into a fight every time you went to this particular class, either, with whoever's teaching it or with the other students, you were fighting, every time you drop the class, you wouldn't continue going in day after day after day after day, or you go you know, with somebody, if you wanted to continue going, and it was the other person was a problem, you'd have to go and try to get it fixed. I don't want to drop this class. This person is causing this problem in my life. You don't keep going back in both relationships. People just keep going back in and keep, like putting up with it. It's like putting up with bad hair, go get another haircut, do something different. But because it's a marriage, or based a living relationship, you think you have to continue to be together. Like why? If you're fighting all the time, you don't belong together. Leave? That's no way to live.

Speaker 2: 1:01:58

Yes, that makes sense. Yeah. And when you do fight, how do you resolve your fights?

Speaker 1: 1:02:06

Say you're sorry. That's it. Like, sorry. I'm yeah, I'm sorry. He'll bring me food. Bring me food, you know, peace offering. So if he should, you know, he used to do this thing where he would hold out like one like a like his Pinky. Like, you could either, you know, like, take your choice, yes or no, it's like, okay, it's over. Like, Okay, we're done. We're done fighting. So we, yeah, we end our fights. We don't, we don't end our fights by getting back into the fight. Oh, okay. So we were fighting about, you know, whether or not we should get new wine glasses, there's something. And so let's now that we've apologized, let's talk about the wine glasses. Again, it's like, no, let's not talk about the wine glasses. Just we're gonna whatever it was, we were because usually what we're fighting about is not something concrete. So if we're fighting about some perceived hurt, then all right, fine. I didn't mean to hurt your feelings. I'm sorry. If I hurt your feelings, let it go. Let's go out and get something to eat together. Let's go. Let's go work in the garden or let's go do something. But yeah, literally a I'm sorry, I didn't mean to piss you off. Or I'm sorry, I didn't know that you were upset anyway, I wouldn't have brought it up whatever it is, and then just move on.

Speaker 2: 1:03:39

What would you say are some challenges in your relationship?

Speaker 1: 1:03:45

So I think the same challenges in our relationship is a challenge. Same challenges it practically every other couple has, which is to you, you know, you meet. You meet you fall in love. You're in

this bubble, right? It's just the two of you, you can't see anybody else in the world. It's just the two of you. And oh, my god, life is going to be just fabulous. Because you found one another, and you're in love, and you're excited. And life is full of possibilities. And oh my god, it's just so wonderful. Because you forgotten that you both have families. And now the whole whole cold hard reality is you have to let the world into your relationship. So that means that you have to meet his family, he has to meet your family. And you're not in love with his family and he's not in love with your family. So you've got to come out of that bubble at some time into the real world and figure out how to make your relationship work when you both come from different families that require things from you. So I think that that is a challenge. For us. We come from different countries. We come from different ethnicities, we come from different languages, and we come from different religions. So pretty much, there's, you know, if we weren't going to make it, and all of that is you go, Oh, you know, I mean, it's so cool because he's different. And he speaks this. And he does that. And it's just wonderful. And I don't see color, and he doesn't see color, we don't care about religion, you've got families, and your families may or may not care about any of those things. So even if they don't, if you especially if you're in a cross cultural relationship, you have to learn his culture. And he has to learn your culture. And that, I think, is probably one of the bigger challenges that we had. Not that we weren't willing to do it. But it is not easy to be for me, for example, when I was younger, it wasn't easy to be the only white woman in the room. Like literally the only white woman, the only white woman in town, if we were traveling back to his country, to be to be the one the only one. It was weird, because I wasn't used to having to do that. And I'm a vegetarian, and he, so we'd go somewhere, and there'd be literally nothing I could do still to this day, we'd go to if we go to one of the events for not me, his family cooks for me. But for the larger extended family. We will be invited to dinner, there will be food everywhere. And there will be literally nothing for me to eat on the table except rice. But I've learned how to do without, before I go, I sit there and make them yourself. Oh, no, I love rice. It's okay. Thank you very much. Because you can't make your host feel bad because they suddenly remember that oh, God, we forgot you were vegetarian, even though you've been in the family for [40-45] years. And there's nothing for you to eat. We're really sorry. Oh, no, no, I'm fine. I'm fine, don't worry. But doing that at this point is really easy doing that, when I was [26-30] was much more difficult, much more challenging. It was much more challenging to walk into a room that had 200 people in it and have the entire room, turn around and look at you and go, Oh, God. And now what do I do? Well, now I know what to do. So I've learned how to work the room of 200 people, and to be comfortable in the room of 200 people at this point, I probably know 150 of them by name. But though that kind of thing is difficult, you come out of that bubble. And now you have to move into his world and learn his world. And equally, he had to come out of the bubble. And had to learn my family's way of doing things, which is very, very different. And trying to explain each other's families and ways and the ways to do things. And he would go off to events on my side and be miserable. But he would do it because he had to. And I'd go off to events on his side and be miserable. But I had to, and you know we'd be driving home to did you have a good time anyway? Nope. So, but you did it, you did it. Because this must this obstacle is here. We can't just stay in our little apartment on [Location] Street, looking into each other's eyes and saying, you know, I think it's wonderful that you're from another culture, you have to actually then go off and learn the other culture. And you either are going to be learned to be comfortable there. Or you're going to spend a lot of miserable years. So for me now I'm perfectly comfortable with the other culture. It's like it's fine. He's really good at moving through my world, and it's fine. And you know, of course, he's in this country now. So my world is also his world. But he still is more comfortable in his own world. Even though he's been here for [40-45] years. He's still more comfortable in his own world, because it's where he was born his own world. But it's so yeah, so I think for us, the fact that we come from different backgrounds, such radically different backgrounds was probably the most challenging thing because it was something we had to do, even if we didn't particularly want to do it. I didn't want to go off to all of those christenings and weddings and

funerals and baptisms and everything else and spend a really uncomfortable hours sitting there trying to talk to people that I had nothing in common with. And plus I was starving because you know, rice only takes you so far. So, or eating some food that I want because it was like So often it would be rice or the dessert table. And, you know, there's just so many desserts you can eat. So, yeah, that was probably for us one of the bigger things that we had to deal with, and completely unexpected because on paper, it all sounds fine. Because I, you know, get a [Nationality]. So we're a really diverse group. It when I, when I say I don't see color, or I don't see, you know, ethnicity or don't care what, I don't care on any level, I truly don't. But it's one thing to not care, it's another thing to have to go deal with his his mom, his dad and his nine brothers and sisters, and, you know, not know how to be with them. So yeah, that kind of thing is that kind of thing is tough.

Speaker 2: 1:10:52

And aside from communication, and like you spend a lot of time together, what are other ways you maintain relationship?

Speaker 1: 1:11:00

I think we maintain it, actually. Also, by giving each other a lot of space. I think I think that's also equally important for us that we, we understand that we need time away from one another as well. Which isn't like he hates things that the guys that say they need a man cave, because they want to be alone. Like it's not that it's not that you know, but it's that you have to have a balance between doing things together and enjoying it, and then actually doing things apart from one another, because and also because you need other people to bring things into your lives. So you need to go off and recharge your batteries out in the greater world without one another. You don't want to be in lockstep together on everything, you have to be really boring, actually. And I also think that you can't make the mistake of thinking that one person, the person in your relationship has to provide for all of your your needs, emotional needs, or even practical needs. If I want to see a movie that he doesn't want to see. I don't you know, burst into tears. And you know, why can't do like [Author] as much as I do. I just go see [Author] with my friends who like [Author], or I go see [Author] movie with friends that like [Author] or go see by myself. And if he wants to go and see something or do something that I don't particularly want to participate in, he wants to go and go to a warrior's game, and I'm kind of, okay with warriors, but I don't really care that much. It's not worth it for me to go. It's much better for him to go off without me go with friends, we're going to really enjoy the game with him. And, you know, let me know, when you're going to a [Team Name] game, I'll go with you. Because I like prefer that. So I think it's, it's good to know, to allow one another, to run to the end of the leash, you've got to be able to give them some freedom and to make to genuinely be able to say, and not in any kind of formulaic way, like, Okay, so we've been doing a lot of things together, I think you really need to go off and do something alone, not like that at all. But in terms of if there's something that comes up that he wants to do, and he mentions it, and my immediate reaction is I don't want to do it. It's got to be wholeheartedly say, oh, go, absolutely go. I'll pay for tickets for you and your friends to go. I really want you to go to this, you have to really genuinely want the other person to go and have the experience without you. Because they need those other people to recharge them. You need to have the foot from other people you can't just hear like otherwise. It's like [Channel Name]. It's one you're only hearing one opinion, you can't hear just one opinion. You need to hear you need other people in your lives. And you have to genuinely allow the other person to go off and have experiences big or small with other people. So yeah, I put that in there also.

Speaker 2: 1:14:19

Actually, I really liked that. Um, what do you say that the relationship is good for you and why?

Speaker 1: 1:14:28

I think it's good for me. At this point. I can't imagine having any other life because I've been having this one for so long. But I do I could. You're right, I could but I could imagine like what have you everyone imagines? What if you'd have been in a different pathway, right? So of course I had different plans when he dropped into my life I was gonna have a different life than the one I have now. I never imagined this particular life. I don't think anybody can think you'd have to be really extraordinary, to be [20-25]. And to be able to say, this is the path I want to go on, and then not veer off of it for the next [40-45] years, I think that would be really amazing if you were able to do it. So I certainly never planned out this life, it just kind of evolves naturally the way that it did. But I can't imagine that I would have had a better life. If I hadn't done this. Like all in all, I think that we're probably both happy 95% of the time, about everything about our relationship about our lives, that 95% of the time, we're really happy with the way that things are. And I think that maybe what's been good for me in this relationship is knowing that I have this really solid foundation, it I don't have to worry that he's going anywhere, I don't have to worry that he's you know, I don't have to worry about infidelity, because I know that he's not going to be unfaithful, but which is always a concern. Because I mean, there's it's just the world continues spinning, and you can't help you being attracted to other people. But that he's not going to act on it in a way that's going to destroy our relationship. The fact that we have this good foundation means that I've got the freedom to be able to make plans, see them through. I don't have the insecurity that comes as not being knowing what tomorrow is going to be like or next week that I've that it's a way of being very it's a very comforting thought that your don't your life is not precarious. So I think that that is good. Because I think that if especially because I do have a thing where I get up in my brain, and I can't keep I get in the loop, and I can't get my brain to turn itself off. This always pulls me back down, like no matter how far out I get out on a limb going, oh my god, that I get pulled, pulled back into this very secure, solid, comforting foundations. And then I know I can rely on it being here. And I know that I can rely on him for anything that happens. Because obviously over the course of all this time, there have been bad things that have happened in our lives. And really super low points and you know, deaths in the family, that kind of thing. But I know that I can rely on him to always be there be my advocate, stay by my side helped me through whatever's going on. So yeah, in that respect is, you know, obviously, really been good.

Speaker 2: 1:18:25

And did the relationship really change you in any way. And if so, how? Or in what way?

Speaker 1: 1:18:36

yeah, I think it's changed. It's changed a lot. It's probably we probably do things really much the same way that we always have done them. We both like to travel. So we usually have a trip planned. So we're usually working on the plans for that. We usually have things going on, we've always had, because we both like how I can't talk anymore. Sorry. [Name]. So we usually have some kind of a house project going on that we're working on. We both like to garden. So we've usually have a garden project, we've got a dog that is easy to so we spent a lot of time with him before he him we had other dogs. And so we usually have something going on where we're doing something with the dog making plans around the dog and the dog's needs. So these but these are things that have always happened. So maybe again, maybe part of the success of the relationship because it was like oh, you know, you've we've changed so much we've changed physically. I don't know that we've changed so much in other ways. I think that we've Thank you coffee has arrived or tea I'm not sure which I think that we He largely are the same people we were when we first got together. And that we know what we know what we'd like to do we know what excites one another. Like I said, I know that if I say breakfast, he'll perk up, doesn't do the same thing for dinner. But he perks up for breakfast. So I think that we've not changed as much. And again, I think that maybe

that's a good thing. Because I think that when you change radically, if the other person can't change along with you, that it, it's almost impossible to keep going. So if I had started off, loving, to travel, loving home design, loving to work in the garden, loving to hang out with the dogs and my friends, dogs loving to go out to eat. And now, I, you know, wanted to sit at the bar every day and drink. I wanted to spend all my time in [Location C], I want to think about the things I would want to do. You know, I want to take lovers because I'm bored. I want to get rid of the dog because I hate her and I want to spend half a year away from you. I can't imagine this would work. The fact that we both still, like the same things that we liked when we were [20-25] and [30-35] or [40-45] and [50-55]. I think it's, it helps. So I don't think that we've changed that much. In what we'd have just said, we're really kind of boring. Because I mean, think of that list of things I just gave you. This is the thing that really thrills me is designing a bathroom. Oh my God, what's its and everything. But we like that. And we're good at it together, we're good at designing things together, we've remodel houses before, with something that we're good at, it's something we like doing, it's something we'd like to do together. And we are happy with the project when it's done. We like going on road trips, and planning how we're gonna go. And figuring out, you know, how many miles you can drive in a day and figuring out where the dog is gonna go and run. We liked doing that stuff. If suddenly one of us didn't like doing that, and there wasn't something to replace it that we both agreed on, then I think that would be a bit of a problem if we change so radically. But I think that that's also maybe that people, they will do change. But I also wonder if they don't, if the problem isn't they weren't honest, to begin with about who they were that the sort of thing that I was telling you about, you know, go while you're young before you fall in love and find yourself trapped in the in the spider web of love, you know, go do what you want to do, because your plans are going to get changed one of the persons involved. I think that maybe a lot of people kind of get sucked into relationships. And they get subsumed by what the other person likes doing. And they're not being true to their own likes and dislikes. And then they get to be [40-45]. And suddenly they're like, oh my god, I'm running out of time. And now I've never wanted to admit that really, I always wanted to be an actress. So I'm leaving and gonna go do that. Whereas you should have just figured, you know, even though he wanted to go be a [interest], if you wanted to be an [interest], you needed to find a way to do both. Otherwise, you can't just you can't defer that for later on in life. And if you've done that, if you've deferred it, then at some point, there's going to be this big fissure, and you're going to split off because you've not been able to really walk the path that you should have walked to begin with.

Speaker 2: 1:24:18

Thanks for sharing that. And I know you kind of touched on this a little bit, but I'm just wondering, like, if you think [Partner's Name] was the same person, they were like he was before the relationship and like and now like if there's a difference or you think he stayed the same

Speaker 1: 1:24:35

Yeah, I think I think he's a lot the same. I think he's grumpier than he used to be that he's always been very happy and very optimistic and very social. I think that he has gotten a little more of the grumpy old man syndrome, as he's at this point, things that wouldn't bother him before, you know, the neighbor's leaving their garbage cans out in front of the house, you know, that kind of thing. I think that that's the only real change I see is that he's gotten a little less tolerant of outsiders behavior, because he's it may just be, because he's home more. But I think that he didn't use to verbalize his dissatisfaction with those things as much as he does now. Aside from that. He's, if he's changed at all, I think he's just probably more comfortable living in the [Country]. So I think he's much more comfortable moving through this world. And whereas when I first we first got together, he didn't used to like to eat out because he wasn't comfortable eating in restaurants, because they didn't use utensils where he came from. So he wasn't comfortable using forks and

knives and spoons. And he felt awkward in the restaurant and didn't want people looking at him, even though he's perfectly capable of eating with a fork. But it wasn't a comfortable thing for him to do eating out was he felt, I think he felt kind of exposed in restaurants. He wasn't comfortable ordering from waiters. And so I would always order. And but I think that he's got I mean, now he's like, you know, he can do all that stuff now. So things that a lot of it, because remember, he's the one that had to come here, not me having to go somewhere else to visit. But I think that he's more comfortable moving through the [Country] world and of the [Country]. And I think that has changed. He's more confident doing that for sure. But other than that he's the same silly human that he was always up for anything. Really high energy. says yes, far more than he ever says no to anything at all. If we wake up at three in the morning, and I say pancakes, we're out the door. We're at [Restaurant Name] we're gone. He's good. He's not somebody who's, you know, it was like that, initially, and he's like that now. So he never, that's not ever changed. I think that he's retained a lot of the same person that he was [40-45] years ago. Like, again, 95% person he was exactly the same. Just he's lost his hair. Yeah.

Speaker 2: 1:28:02

Do you feel safer in the relationship? And why do you say so?

Speaker 1: 1:28:16

I'm sorry, you broke up just then.

Speaker 2: 1:28:17

Oh, I'm sorry. Um, I was just wondering, do you feel safe in the relationship? And why do you say so?

Speaker 1: 1:28:26

Oh, safe, like physically safe in the relationship. Emotionally, emotionally or safe? Physically?

Speaker 2: Both both.

Speaker 1: Okay, yeah. So physically? Yeah. Okay, good. So physically, absolutely. And I come from a, let me see, how do we put this politely? I learned, I learned this phrase, to say it lightly. I grew up in a violent household. That's why you say it. So I grew up with a stepfather who was physically abusive to my mother. And if so, yeah, I am extremely familiar with this. And I am absolutely 100% confident that I am safe in this relationship physically. Because as a daughter who grew up in that situation, if any guy had ever lifted a hand to me, I would be gone instantly. Because what I know from that is if you don't go immediately, you never go. You can't go. And at least and that's I think just as true for young women today, as it was for my mother's generation. It seems like there should be more avenues for a woman getting out of a relationship. And certainly it's changed that you can now call 911 and the cops have to come whereas they didn't. Back in when I was a child. The police came. They said it was a family affair and they they left so that did change and they're certainly more aware. Ernests have that kind of behavior in households. And there was when, you know, [16-20], that's when my stepfather show up. And I think in the [Year]s There's certainly a lot more. But I still think that women, especially women, who might have children in a relationship, find themselves financially, very challenged to get out of the relationship, if not just downright terrified to leave, because the things can get very ugly even after you're gone. So I know that if he had ever, which he would not, if he were a violent man, I would not be with him. So. So that is, you know, a for sure answer for that. Do I feel emotionally safe? Yeah, absolutely. Yeah, I feel that. I think he tells me most things, things are popping up on my screen. I think he tells me most things that are going on. With him, I think I tell him most things that are going on with me. I am somebody who does find it difficult. If I'm having a really deep negative emotion, maybe a memory of something that's negative, it's bad. sad memory. I'm have difficulty saying opening my mouth and saying I'm feeling bad about especially if I'm feeling bad about

something that happened [11-15] years ago, or [30-35] years ago. And I'm thinking about, you know, a pet that we've lost or something that has something traumatic that happened, but I'm still thinking about it. I'm somebody who has trouble saying that. So I will tend to not say that to him. But I know I could. So I could say, I'm feeling really bad because I'm thinking about the dog that we had that we lost. And I know that he would have a good reaction to it. It's just I'm the one that just my family was not good at expressing that kind of thing. So we tend to bottle it up. But I know that I could do it. I know that the thing that's that I so yes, I know, I'm safe, emotionally expressing those things to him. And that I would get a good and healing reaction from him if I allow myself to to it.

Speaker 2: Yeah, right. And it's great with me. Awesome. The next part of this interview is going to be like with the likert scale. So I'm going to share my screen real quick. So can you see the slide show that I have?

Speaker 1: I'm going to take my glasses off because I can actually see my glasses on. Yeah, that's right. Okay. This is loading. Loading. You're in the upper right hand corner. Still loading. Okay. I'll drink coffee because it'll eventually help.

Speaker 2: So. I'll change my wifi, and maybe that will help.

Speaker 1: City's capital spending is doing its thing. So there it is. All right, my partner, I need you to really close up because I could grab my other glasses, but it's good. All right. My partner usually really listens to me. Is he not at all somewhat true? Oh, this is fun. Somewhat true.

Speaker 2: Okay. And why would you pick so three?

Speaker 1: Three. Yeah. Sorry. I just saw the numbers. Sorry. Today? Yes. Oh, aren't you very. Oh, I'm sorry. I'm on the wrong end of the scale. Seven. I'm sorry I failed. Seven. Yes. Yes, Very true. Okay. Okay. He does usually Yeah. I'm so sorry. I'm just. I'm down at the other end here. It's illogical, because why would it be on the bottom end? Okay, now I see the numbers. Okay. Yes. Yeah, very true. Not completely true. He doesn't always. He doesn't usually really listen to me. That's sometimes ignored. Yeah. No, he does. He does. Listen to me. Yeah. Yeah. Seven.

Speaker 2: Why Not like, moderately true. Like six, five, six, four area.

Speaker 1: um because. I think he spits the information back out at me. So I know that he has heard what I've said. So I know that he's not he's he's getting the full message and has assimilated the information. And if it was only moderately true, then it'd be like, Yeah, he's listening to me half the time. I don't think he's listening to me half the time. I think he was listening to me three quarters of the time. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Right. Because, like. Right. If I'm trying to teach you something, if I tell you two plus two is four and you're like, okay, I got it to ask you to teach it back to me. If you can't teach it back to me, you haven't learned it. So the saying, okay, if you can't spit it back to me, what I've just said. Then he's not listening. But he can spit it back to me. So I know he is listening. Yeah. I'm going with seven.

Speaker 2: Okay, awesome. the next one is my partner usually is responsive to my needs.

Speaker 1: Oh, yeah. Nine.

Speaker 2: And why not eight or like seven.

Speaker 1: My needs, whatever that is. If my need is for coffee. Because because he's honestly 100% responsive to my needs. Whatever I need, he yeah, whatever I need, anything I need, whatever it is. If I need a hand to get off the couch because I you know, I'm stuck on the couch, he he's there. If I need him to go get me something from the store, pick up a prescription or something, he gets it. If I need him to do something for a friend, he does it. Yeah. No, he's completely is absolutely responsive. He's a good guy.

Speaker 2: How satisfied are you with the relationships? This is not like a number. But what would you say on this scale?

Speaker 1: Oh, this is interesting. So am I definitely satisfied or completely satisfied? I think about that for a second. And. I'm going to say I'm completely satisfied. And rather than vary because what else could I possibly want from this relationship? You know. I mean, I wish he was a prince with \$1,000,000,000 in the bank, but I don't think that that really plays in and that would just be convenient. That would just mean you'd have more cheese in the refrigerator. But yeah, I can't think. Of anything that I would want. Relationship wise. I mean, this is somebody that I want to spend time with. I'm excited about doing things with still. I'm. Happy to. Have in the same room with me. Pretty much 100% of the time. So yeah, we're going with is completely satisfied.

Speaker 2: And then a similar thing is before, like a numbers go. Where would you put yourself there?

Speaker 1: Okay, so we're going to put me at a ten.

Speaker 2: And why not like a nine?

Speaker 1: Yeah, because again. In order for it to be less than completely satisfied, there have to be something that I would wish were different. And I can't imagine anything that I wish was different. This is someone who sees to my needs 100%, but tells me I'm on. Right? Like, yeah, what more? What? Just again, relationship wise, what on earth would I want to change? No, nothing. Got to be a ten.

Speaker 2: That was awesome. Yeah. Okay, so those are all with the scale. And I only have two questions. Okay. Okay, So these next few questions are slightly more personal. And if they're too sensitive, like, feel free to share another person's whiteboard. But no, we don't want to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple. So these days, how often do you have sex?

Speaker 1: We don't right now because I have got a really, really bad right hip and which you can imagine, which isn't to say that that's going to stay that way. But currently we're not having sex. And I. think that we need to get back to that, because I do think that it's a really important. Aspect. I do. And it was always a really big, and I think it's a big part. Well, I guess it's a big part of everybody's relationship. But we also have a really healthy sex life, really enthusiastic sex life, let's put it that way. So. But right now, yeah, we aren't having sex at all right now. Unfortunately, just because it's physically busy and I know there's other things that we could do, but I haven't been feeling very well lately. I'm feeling better now. I've actually been this has been probably the best month for a while. I've had, like some health issues for the last [1-5] years, but they're being resolved. And so I'm hoping I'm sure he's hoping too. But that. We can rekindle that part of the relationship. And I'm pretty sure that that's something we can do. Yeah, unfortunately, that's the only thing I can. Can't give you a ten on.

Speaker 2: And that goes with my next question. How satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker 1: Yes. So right now, not except my own personal records, You know, that's always good. But yeah, not satisfied at all. That would be a zero. That would be an yeah, not satisfied because it's nonexistent at this particular point. So that too is mental because it's. Difficult as you age to feel terribly attractive. And I think and I know it's that's a mental thing. I know there's some people that just don't have a problem with that, but I think that sex is controlled a lot by your brain. It always has been for me, and yes it's controlled by your hormones. But I don't have those anymore. I don't think so. Your. It's as much of a mental. Event as a physical event. I think it is maybe not for men because they're built differently. But for women, I think because it would not just we can't necessarily orgasm with just physical stimulation if it's not just right. And so we need to have that mental bit locked in as well. And so. I think that. If you're not feeling your best physically, you can't get that part of your brain to engage either. That so you're. It's almost like having to relearn a language. So I think that's part of the stumbling block at this point is I need to relearn that

language, but I need to find a way. To learn it with this new baseline. Rather than trying to get back to. Something previous I don't think was in my mind when I think about it and I do my mind and I think about it like, God, you know, I can't get myself into that place that I need to. Yeah. That's another person. And I need to be able to do that. So I need to get in. Need to get my brain around this. Need to realize that. Yes. Get in there. Got a case and plan next week. Is a good thing. Is it? My. In my experience. So. Yeah. Fingers crossed. Yeah. We'll see. We'll see what we can do.

Speaker 2: Thank you for sharing that. Yeah. So those are all the questions I have. Before we wrap up, I'm just going to summarize a bit of what we talked about. So it seems like you're very satisfied with your relationship. You. main your relationship with communication, having quality time together, but also quality time apart. And you both love each other a lot, which is another part of what makes you. Satisfied in your relationship? Is there anything that you'd like to add or anything that I missed?

Speaker 1: No, I think you've got it all. I certainly did talk a lot. Yeah, I think it's a really interesting what you're doing. I think it's fascinating. What a great study to do. Really, honestly, because it's like, wow, people actually want to talk about these things, to think about these things. I think that the only thing I have to say is I think that this kind of study is really, really important because, um, I do think that I have know people with more unhappy relationships than happy relationships, and they stay in those relationships. And I wonder why they do. And I mean, I understand why they do. I understand practically why they do. But I think that studies like this could be really helpful. Trying to define what does make a good relationship and. What do you need to do to be, you know, [40-45] years in and say, I'm completely satisfied? You know, we're not. Unusual people. It's not as though we have some special skills for this. We are two people that should never have met each other or gotten together, shouldn't have even been on the same continent. And so this relationship by for all intents and purposes, should not work at all. And you will meet him shortly and you will see that we are very, very, very different people. And he. I have no idea what he's going to say to any of these things, quite frankly. It's going to be really sad when the other on the other end, he says. It doesn't work. I can't stand her. But, you know, that's it is, too. It's amazing that people get together at all. It truly is. Think about it. Think how it is that two people ever get together. And so the fact that you able to get together and then you're able to sustain it to any degree is kind of a miracle. So I don't know if it's a miracle that actually has. Data that could be attached to it, to say these are things that you need to have in order to be able to answer these questions in a positive way. And if you don't have these things you need, you need to consider whether you're in the right relationship or not. Because I think that. And to put it another way, I didn't want to stay with him when I was [20-25]. I didn't want this relationship. I wanted to go and do other things. But it was so obvious that. I wasn't going to find this anywhere else. So it's. Yeah, I think I'm really, really lucky to have found him and to have gotten together and to have pulled this off for this long. So, yeah. Hey, you're doing good work.

Speaker 2: I really appreciate it. And I think that's actually part of like what we're setting is just like what makes a relationship. Higher quality or lower quality. And it kind of breaks into like another thing that I want to ask is the way that we're doing this research is through snowball sampling, which I think you don't. That is what you ask your participants to recommend to other people to participate. So some people that we're actually looking for is people in like lower satisfaction. Oh, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. And we're also looking for people. I don't know if some people, but like people in most sexual relationships, are also like in LGBTQ plus relationships, like a lesbian couple, gay couple, any of those kind of people who like argue more or have like, a lower satisfaction in the relationship? Mm hmm. So if you do. Yeah. Let me think about who we know. Yeah. I can also send you. I will also serve you like a text message. Or I don't know what you prefer, but like texts, your email regarding, like. Oh, yeah. texts. Either one doesn't matter. Okay. Okay. I'll tell you. That's what I personally prefer, but yeah. Yeah. It's like. It's like, okay, awesome. Yeah. I'll send you a text regarding, like, what kind of people we're looking for in case you do though. Or if you know, also, like, no people. Yeah, the people that would be super helpful. So either of those would be good.

Speaker 1: Yeah, exactly. Yes, exactly. Yeah I know it's hard to find study subjects, so. Yeah, yeah, yeah. I've got a friend who does who does does trials in stay at [Location]. And the challenge is always trying to get people, you know, to get them on the trial. Yeah, they've got everything set up, but it's trying to get, get the bodies that's with the difficult bar. So. Yeah, absolutely. Send me the stuff. Let me think about who we know and who they might know and yeah, absolutely.

Speaker 2: Yeah. Okay. Awesome. I will send you all the information after this and then. Okay, awesome. And then I just have, like, one more thing. Sorry. And never handling the data. We have two different data options. So the first one is that transcript portions can be shared, none of which can be identified to you, so that the transcript can be read by other researchers in option two is kind of like a boulder option. So that's like the whole transit can be shared and will be removed of sensitive and overly identified details. So it will be anonymized, although in this option there's a minimal chance that someone who knows you can piece together like the details in the transcript and they're down. Who among their colleagues believe it is. Although again, no sensitive information will be shared, and it's quite unlikely that someone will figure out that it's yours. Even if they read this. So yeah, but which of those two options sounds better?

Speaker 1: Yeah, you can do the you can do the the one where you share everything. It's fine. I think. Yeah. I don't care. I, I don't care if you don't, if you don't take out the sensitive things like who cares what I have to say anyway. Right. And I would I haven't said anything to you actually, that I wouldn't say to anybody who asked me. So, yeah, go right ahead. Share it all. Okay, So the better.

Speaker 2: Okay. Sounds good. Okay. Well, good. Oh, yeah. I will send you a text message. And thank you so much for getting this. I really appreciate it. And you gave really good information .

Speaker 1: Yeah. Oh, good. I'm glad. So do you need to take off, take a break before you talk to [Partner's Name], because you've been, like, working for an hour. He wants to talk to you.

Speaker 2: I honestly think I think it might be best if [Partner's Name] came, like, right now.

Speaker 1: Okay. Okay. So I'm going to tell you that he has a little bit of a hearing issue, and we're on my phone with with my headset rather than he has better quality AirPods.